

Task 5

Cybercrime Awareness Case Study & Prevention Guide

Case Study: UPI/Online Payment Fraud

UPI (Unified Payments Interface) fraud is a rapidly growing cybercrime in India, where fraudsters manipulate users into transferring money or revealing sensitive banking details. With the rise of apps like Google Pay, PhonePe, and Paytm, digital payments have become convenient—but also vulnerable.

A common scenario involves a college student, Rohan, selling a used phone online. A scammer poses as a buyer and sends a fake payment request link, claiming it is to “receive” money. Step-by-step, the fraud occurs as follows:

1. The scammer contacts the victim via a marketplace or social media.
2. They build trust and agree to make payment via UPI.
3. Instead of sending money, they send a “collect request” or a fake payment link.
4. The victim, unaware, enters their UPI PIN thinking they are receiving money.
5. The amount is instantly debited from the victim’s account.

Such frauds typically target students, elderly individuals, and first-time digital payment users who may lack awareness of UPI mechanisms. Scammers often exploit urgency, trust, or lack of technical knowledge.

The consequences can be severe, including financial loss, emotional stress, and compromised banking security. In many cases, victims struggle to recover funds due to the instant nature of UPI transactions. This highlights the importance of digital literacy, verifying payment requests, and never sharing UPI PINs. Awareness and cautious behavior remain the strongest defenses against such frauds.